

POLAR REGIONS

The top and bottom of Earth are icy wildernesses, enduring long, dark winters with sub-zero temperatures. Neither region has a permanent population living there, although scientists and explorers visit both to find out more about these extraordinary places.

Arctic Ocean

The North Pole sits on a thick cushion of ice that floats on top of the Arctic Ocean. This ice cap expands and shrinks throughout the year, reaching the coastlines of Canada, Alaska, and Russia in the winter months. During the summer, however, it retreats, allowing ships to sail around its edges.



Icebreaker ships

Specially built ships with strengthened hulls clear a passage through the Arctic ice during the winter months to allow ships to sail around the southerly edges of the ocean.

Arctic wildlife

The Arctic Ocean is mostly inhabited by mammals with thick layers of insulating blubber, such as whales and seals, as well as polar bears on its ice cap.